

A PHOTOGRAPH

By- SHIRLEY TOULSON

Theme:-

The theme of the poem revolves around loss, mortality and separation. In the poem, The poet's mother grows up quickly and misses her youth which is now lost. After her mother's death the poet remembers the past and feels sad. According to her, humans are short-lived and transient Humans change quickly unlike the sea which is immortal and does not change. The transient and mortal nature of humans lead to separation and loss. Her sorrow cannot be expressed in words so she remains silent in the end.

Main points:

The poet recollects how her mother laughed at the old photograph of her sea holiday. She also felt disappointed at the same time at the loss of her childhood joys. The sea holiday was her mother's past; while the mother's smile is the poet's past. At different points of time both of them try to reconcile with their respective losses with great difficulty. For the poet, the death of her mother brings great sadness and an acute sense of loss. The painful "silence" of the situation leaves her with no words to express her grief. Thus, the silence silences her.

Question 1. What does the word 'cardboard' denote in the poem? Why has this word been used?

Answer: The word cardboard denotes the photograph pasted

on a hard thick paper. This word has been used to refer to a practice in the past when photographs were pasted on cardboard and framed with a glass frame to preserve them.

Question 2: What has the camera captured?

Answer: The camera has captured the three girls-the poet's mother and her two cousins, Betty and Dolly, in their swimming dresses with the poet's mother in the middle and the two cousins on either side holding her hands.

Question 3: In what context has the phrase "terribly transient feet" been used in the poem?

Answer: Human life is very short lived, transitory and temporary as compared to the sea which is a symbol of permanence, immortality and eternity. The poet uses the phrase 'terribly transient feet' to highlight the temporal nature of human life. The life of a human being is nothing as compared to the life of a sea.

Question 4: What has not changed over the years? Does this suggest something to you?

Answer: The sea has not changed over the years. Its waves are as fresh, shining and tireless as they were years ago. The permanence of sea reminds us of the changes in human face with advancing age.

Question 5: The poet's mother laughed at the snapshot? What did this laugh indicate?

Answer: The dress and behavior of her cousins Betty and

Dolly made the poet's mother laugh. It is evident that they had put on some quaint dress, which amused her. This laugh indicated her joy at remembering an incident connected with her past life, when she was quite young and free from the tensions and worries of life.

Question 6: What is the meaning of the line "Both wry with the laboured ease of loss".

Answer: The sea holiday and the laughter of the poet's mother are incidents of the past. There is a sense of loss associated with them. Both are amusing yet disappointing as the state of feeling comfortable or relaxed is unnatural or forced. This sense of loss is quite painful to bear.

Question 7: The three stanzas depict three different phases. Name them.

Answer: The girlhood of the poet's mother-the period before the birth of the poet. Her middle age-the period during the childhood of the poet. Period after the death of the poet's mother.

Question 8: The poet's mother laughs at her past. How does the poet react to her past?

Answer: The sea holiday was a past experience for the poet's mother. A glimpse of the photograph perhaps revived some feelings of shared joy and she laughed. For the poet, her laughter is an incident of the past. It is amusing in an ironic manner. The sense of loss overcomes pleasure.